Quantity versus quality approach also encourages corrupt practices at customer's expense, where subpar solutions are pushed down customer's throat by leveraging their ignorance and an urge to give in to the fear of missing out (also called as FOMO). This is especially true with several technologies that are going through the hype cycle; AI is one of them.

The problem with these low-quality solutions is that flaws in subpar techs do not surface until it is too late! In many cases, the damage is already done and may be irreversible.

Unlike many other technologies, where things work or do not work, there is a significant grey area with AI solutions that can change shades over a period. Moreover, if we are not clear in which direction that will be, we end up creating junk. This junk essentially means someone somewhere has wasted a lot of money in creating and nurturing these solutions. It also indicates that several customers may have suffered or have had negative experiences, courtesy junk solutions.

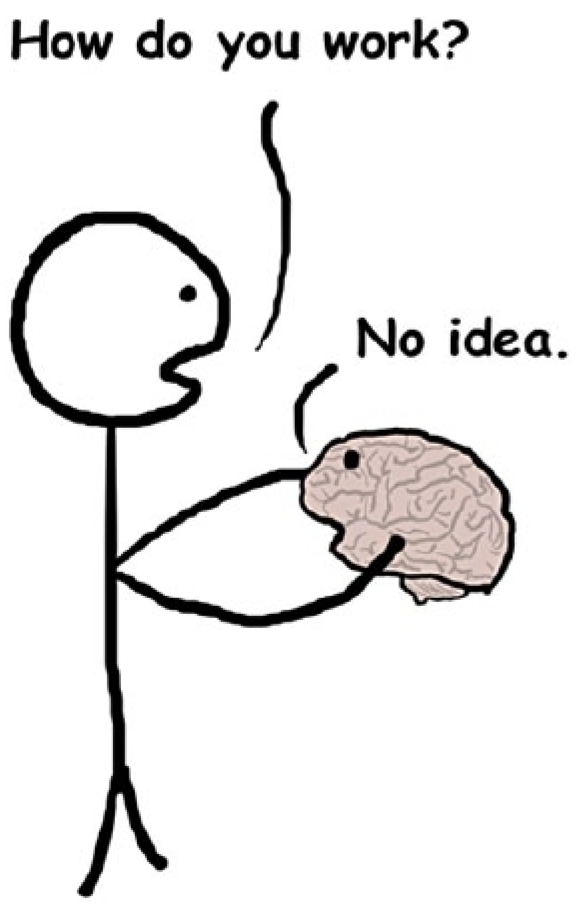
We not only need to challenge the quality of every solution but also improvise our approach towards the emerging technologies in general, AI included.

Have you seen a balanced-scorecard for AI?

The absence of a balanced-scorecard has adversely affected sales departments for several decades and instilled many predatory and deceptive sales practices. It happened because one of the goals for the sales team was to maximise sales numbers. However, it often lacked some of the finer details and did not specify acceptable methods of sale to achieve those goals.

Contention and racing, or conflicting objectives, are often the cause of friction within various teams and people. With AI in the picture, there is a matter of scale. That is, AI-powered solutions are known for their efficiency and effectiveness at a massive level. Therefore misalignment between our goals and the machine's goals could be dangerous. It is easier to course-correct a team of humans; doing that with a rampant machine could be a very tricky and arduous task.

If you command your autonomous car, "Take me to the hospital as quickly as possible," it may have terrible consequences. Your car may take you to the hospital quickly as you asked, but it may leave behind a trail of several accidents. Without you specifying that the rules of the road must be followed and no humans should be harmed, and it should not take dangerous turns, and several other common-sense fundamentals, your car will end up turning into a 2-tonne weaponised metal block.



Achieving a level of alignment with human-level common sense is quite tricky for a computerised system. Without having any balanced approach like a scorecard, this may not be achievable.

Misaligned or confused and conflated goals of an AI system are going to be a significant concern of the future, as the AI will be extremely good at achieving its goals, but those goals may not represent what we really wanted.

Know 'how' but not 'why'? We have a problem

AI solutions are usually excellent in performing any given task efficiently, effectively, and at scale, consistently. However, knowing how to perform a specific task sometimes is not the only thing one needs to know. Understanding the purpose of the job is equally essential, since it can give a valuable context to the task itself. Understanding this context is helpful not only for performing the task but also for improvising, as and when required, and ensuring that all the relevant bases are covered.

Technology is an answer to 'how' of the strategy, but without having the right 'why' and 'what' in place, it can do more damage than good.

One of the sources of bias in AI solutions is failing to know 'why.' For example, your car insurance company may tell you that you are not insurable because the system says so. And the system says so because it has data that shows you were going above the speed limit. Would anyone even know why you were driving above the speed limit? Could it be the case of an emergency where you had to break the rule? Only by understanding why it would make more sense in such cases. But it is quite possible that your insurance company may not even ask you about this and decline the cover.

When AI systems do not know why, there is always going to be a lurking risk of discrimination, bias, or an illogical outcome.

Right solution - wrong hands

I always say that tools and systems are not hurtful; people using them are! The thing with technology is that, if you learn to use it, it works for you. But 'who' you are will decide 'how' you use it.

Notably, the interface between humans and AI systems is one of the risky areas. Not just during the use of the systems, these risks are prevalent in preliminary stages of AI training,